
> **blog** > **outside in**

CAN POETRY SAVE THE WORLD?

An interview with Franco 'Bifo' Berardi

BY MIKE HUGUENOR, 5 JULY 2019

RIGHT now, you are not reading my words. What you are reading is lines upon lines of code. Code is in your car, your TV, and in the photos you take. It is inscribed in thermostats, prison security systems, and the transactions of Wall Street. At a fundamental level, code is language. But for Italian philosopher Franco 'Bifo' Berardi, it is not as simple as that. For Berardi, code and language have a very specific relation: 'Code,' Berardi writes in *Breathing: Chaos & Poetry*, 'is language in debt.'

To understand what Berardi means we need only look at how codes function. Code, Berardi points out, is 'the imposition of a performative and productive limit'. Code is the connecting of pre-defined syntactical strains. In its functioning, it creates new limitations, defining what inputs are allowed, and what outputs these inputs generate.

Poetry, on the other hand, has a transformative power: it 'reopens the indefinite'. Instead of smooth functionality, poetry creates new errors, bringing about dazzling, illustrative, haunting contradictions, which expand what it means to be human. While code operates on a logic of direct exchange (for example, the string '<i>' in HTML exchanges directly with an italic font), poetry 'is the language of *nonexchangeability*.'

But the stakes are greater than just the matter of code and language. For Berardi, the stakes are nothing less than the continued breathing of humanity, which he sees as being choked by financial capitalism — peoples and governments of the world incapable of combating a system that is everywhere and nowhere at once. Poetry, he suggests, is the only answer.

→ Also read Antonio Negri, "I
experience of Italy in the 197
diplomatie, September 19

Maybe it all sounds a little esoteric. What, after all, does poetry have to do with finance? In his 2011 book, *The Uprising, Breathing*, Berardi makes the point that finance has already been affected by poetry. The term 'deregulation,' a rallying point for fans of free market economics, was first coined by Arthur Rimbaud, whose '*dérèglement des sens et des mots*,' was a call for the 'deregulation of signs and words.' It is this same impulse, Berardi suggests, which is behind the functioning of finance. In a strange sense, without Rimbaud there would be no Paul Ryan.

Before he was a renowned philosopher, Berardi was an early figure in pirate radio, the founder of Milan station Radio Alice, which beginning in the mid-'70s operated out of a hijacked ex-military transmitter. Later that decade, he moved to New York to cover the post-punk movement for a music magazine back in Italy. More recently, his work has focused on finance and technology, as well as the phenomena of mass shootings, suicide by cop, and Trumpism.

On the day we spoke, children all across the world marched to protest inaction on climate change. Though it

wasn't planned, it was an appropriate backdrop for a conversation with one of philosophy's most insurrectionary thinkers.

You open *Breathing* by writing about Eric Garner, who in 2014 was choked to death by the NYPD for selling loose cigarettes. What does this have to do with poetry?

First of all because, I am asthmatic like Eric Garner. I was in the United States during those days for a conference. The day that the video concerning the death — the *martyr* — of Eric Garner came to the public, I was in California. I took part in demonstrations that shouted 'I can't breathe, I can't breathe.' For me, the expression 'I can't breathe' means something special because I suffer from respiratory crisis from time to time.

But at the same time, this morning, I went from my home — I live in the center of the city of Bologna. I heard some shouting outside. It was a demonstration of very, very, very young people. The crusade of the children, like in many places in the world. People are marching, demonstrating against the suffocation of humankind.

Greta Thunberg (who happens to be an autistic person, diagnosed as unable to distinguish nuances — unable to distinguish grays), has awakened the consciousness of the generation on a very clear black-and-white point. And this point is: capitalism is suffocating us. I look at how this consciousness is actually spread among the tens of millions of young people who have been marching. This is a movement that will last for years. And the real enemy of this movement is suffocation. But if you look beyond suffocation, you see growth, competition, and profit. I call it 'capitalism'.

March 15th is an important day, in my opinion. In a sense, it's a day that will be expressed much better by poetry than by politics. Politics, the art of the technique of government, is unable to understand it, this challenge. It's unable because politics has been borne inside the framework of growth, expansion, competition, and profit. But people are marching in the streets. And I feel that they are saying, 'I can't breathe'.

There is a word that is central to your work, but which might not be familiar to most people. That word is 'semio-capital.' Can you explain what you mean by that?

Well, 'Semio-' of course, refers to the word *semeion*, which in Greek means 'Sign.' So what I'm saying is that capitalism, today, can be described as a very complex system based on the production and circulation of signs. One may tell me, 'Oh, no. I use a car, and a car is not a sign.' So, capitalism is also producing cars, and coffee, and buildings. Right. But the production *process* that makes it possible to produce a car is a semiotic process: a computer, a program, software, and so on, and so on. So I choose to define capitalism as semio-capitalism, because it is based on the informatisation of the production process.

Some people may see things like, for example, *Pokémon GO*, or the many online dating communities, as ways to reconnect people in a digital age. But you make a distinction between 'connection' and 'conjunction.'

I think it is absolutely crucial, this distinction. I define conjunction as any kind of relation between human beings. More specifically, between *linguistic agents*. When we enter in a relation, we are exchanging linguistic signs. In the conjunctive relation, we are *creating* the meaning of what we exchange. If I tell you 'I like you,'

or 'I dislike you,' in a situation which is physically embodied, I am creating, at a physical-body proximity level, the contextual conditions for our understanding, our exchange.

What is a code actually? Code is a philosophical picture, which is similar to prophecy.

The connective relation, on the other hand, is a purely syntactic relation. I mean, if you put a machine in contact with another machine, you need a common format. A common syntax. What they exchange, the meaning they are exchanging, those two machines, is independent from the context. It is purely syntactic. In a sense, the meaning is already contained in the syntax itself. What I say is that this kind of machinic relation is expanding more and more to the human beings, because we are more and more relating through machines that demand a format, a syntactic format. We need to speak the language of the machine, otherwise we will never be understood.

What is a code actually? Code is a philosophical picture, which is similar to *prophecy*. Prophecy is a linguistic act, which contains in itself a projection of the future. The same as code. Code is a linguistic tool, which contains, in itself, the future deployment of the coded object. This is important because we are entering into a dimension in which *prophecy* is replaced by *code*. And that is redefining the function of language in a sense. I see a danger in this. Because I see that our future, the future of human beings, is more and more inscribed in the coded string of language. Prophecy is not self-fulfilling. Prophecy never describes the future in a prescriptive way. But code is doing that. Code is prescribing the future as the only future that can be.

This is something that code shares with finance. In finance, speculation itself determines worth. Once 'confidence' goes down, the worth itself goes down, whether or not anything else changed.

Absolutely. What is finance? Finance is the semiotic transcription of the economic word. In the beginning, finance is just a kind of transcription of what happens in the real world of the physical economy in numerical terms, in financial terms. But at a certain point — since say the year 1971 when President Nixon decided that the American dollar has no relation with the real economy — there is a sort of autocratic force in the field of the world economy. Since that moment, finance changed its nature. Because finance, which started as a transcription, started to become a *prescription*. What happens in the field of finance is projected, immediately, in the field of the real relations between economic agents.

This is the reason why many times we feel trapped. I would say more and more we feel trapped. Think of the Greek people in the summer of 2015. They went to the polls. 62% of the Greeks voted against the financial memorandum of the European bank. And the day after, [former Greek Prime Minister] Alexis Tsipras was obliged to bend to the decisions of the Central Bank. Why? Because the real decision of millions of Greeks is trapped inside the financial prescription. You cannot go, by definition, outside of the prescription.

My perception is that the growing fascism, the growing racism, that we are obliged to see every day in the United States, like in Italy (like in the United Kingdom, like in Hungary, like in many, many places), the new fascism is originated, generated, by a sort of rage. By a blind rage which is the rage against the mathematical ferocity of the mathematical code. We are living inside the corpse of capitalism. But we can't find a way out. Because this corpse is a mathematical corpse.

But then here comes poetry. My idea of poetry is not based on literature. It's based on the erotic dimension of

language. Only the reactivation of the erotic dimension of language, and of the linguistic body, the social body — only these reactivations can give us a new perception of freedom, in front of the financial machine.

A lot has changed between when you wrote *The Uprising*, and when you wrote *Breathing*. What is it that poetry is doing now?

First of all, you are right: I wrote *The Uprising* in the year 2011. In writing that book, I was travelling from London, to Rome, to NYC, to Beirut, to Cairo, Spain, taking part in that movement. The year of occupation. What have we been occupying and why? The occupation could appear as a nonsensical action. We occupy the streets, but power is not in the streets. Financial power is not in the streets. Financial power is nowhere. Not even in the banks! It is in cyberspace, in a purely abstract dimension that we cannot touch, we cannot stop, we cannot destroy.

So why go to the street and occupy? My answer was: we have not tried to stop financial capitalism. We have tried to *reactivate our body*. This is why we took to the streets. This was a poetical action, not a political action. We were not reclaiming something from power. We were saying something to ourselves. We were telling ourselves: we are alone in our cubicles, in front of our screens. We are working together, and living alone. So stop working together, and stop living alone! Let's go to the street.

But, as we know, that movement has not been lucky, and has not successful. On the contrary, the financial dictatorship has gone on. And, at the end, that movement has been diluted in many places, or, like in Egypt, destroyed. So what happens now? Now, I look at the street, and I see that this new generation — new in a strong sense, because this is the crusade of the children. This is not the movement of the University. This is the movement of the elementary schools. And the strength — the *enormous strength* of this movement — is one: it's a formative moment of a new generation that is suffocating. Literally suffocating. Second: this movement is absolutely radical, and it is going to be in the next days, weeks, and months. Third: the language of this movement cannot be the old language of politics. Power, parliament, democracy, tyranny, good politics, bad politics — no way! The problem is no more in the old Machiavellian sense, or the Leninist sense, to govern society from above. The only possibility is to *recreate* society from below.

Finance, which started as a transcription, started to become a prescription.

But what means below? From *the body*. From the breathing body of human singularities. This is the knowledge of this movement, in my opinion. This is the continuation of Occupy, with a goal which is much more precise than 10 years ago. Because the movement of Occupy was against violence. Difficult thing. How can you act on violence? You cannot even see the figures, the statistics, the numbers. If you say, 'I want to stop suffocation,' you are talking therapy, you are talking about the city, about transportation, about time of labor, about the obligation of working in horrible conditions. This movement is much more concrete than Occupy. And, at the same time, it's the continuation of the same thread.

The 'poetic reactivation of the social body.'

Yes. The expression I use, I know it's a bit ridiculous, but I say 'the poetic reactivation of the social body.' Of

course it's a metaphor. But what should I do? I use metaphors. And poets do as well, they use metaphors. But when poets use metaphors, they are not talking for themselves, or for two or three intimate friends, they are finding words that are able to make clear what was totally confused. To explain to crowds what is at the foundation of life. Metaphors are tools for understanding. And words that function as tools for understanding. What we need to understand now is that capitalism is a corpse. And the only way out from capitalism is reducing the pressure of labor. Of the obligation to work.

One point you make, which is fascinating, is that 'deregulation' as a concept comes from Rimbaud. Does poetry almost have a responsibility to counteract its own creation?

Once again, we are talking metaphors. We are definitely in the metaphorical field, and we need to understand the meaning and the direction of the metaphors. So, I read Arthur Rimbaud, and I read the word *dérèglement*, which translated in English is 'deregulation.' Is it a purely accidental coincidence? No, it is not. Because in the second part of the 19th century and the first part of the 20th century, all the work of poets, of painters, of musicians, has been aimed at abstraction, in a very strange way. As we know, 'abstract' is a very important word for painting and for poetry in the past century, the century of the avant-gardes. But essentially, that kind of abstraction can be seen as the emancipation of the sign from the referent. When Rimbaud, or Mayakovsky, or Picasso paints or writes a certain word or a certain image, he is not referring to an identifiable referent. He is *inventing a new word*. He is creating a word. This is an enormous change in the field of art and poetry. But this is also the anticipation, one hundred years before, of a gesture (in a very different world and with very different intentions) Richard Nixon made in 1971. When Richard Nixon says 'money is no more,' the meaningful translation of the referent: money is autonomous. Money is creating a word for itself. He is doing the same semiological action as Mallarmé and of Van Gogh. Obviously this is a metaphor. Someone can say: 'So what? What is the point in this analogy?' The point is that poetry is, by definition, irresponsible. The responsibility of poets is not juridical, it is not legal, not political. Nevertheless, poets have an enormous responsibility when it comes to signs, to words, to concepts, to images. So this is why we are shifting from the dimension of Occupy, the fight against abstraction, to Greta Thunberg, who is calling people to rediscover their concrete body, which is suffocating.

→ Also read Antonio Negri, "I experience of Italy in the 1970s", *diplomatique*, September 19

So, then, the question. Can poetry save us?

Nobody will save us. Nothing will save us, and I don't want to be saved actually. We have to understand: the real point is you will die, sooner or later. And me, and everybody. So the problem of extinction. The concept of extinction is entering the history of the human kind with a new strength and a new consciousness.

Did you see the last work of David Bowie, *Blackstar*? It's all about extinction. David Bowie is a great poet, first of all, but he is the first poet to stage his own death, his own extinction. So, we will die. Also in *Blade Runner*, Pris, the beautiful replicant, says: 'we are stupid, and we will die.' If we understand extinction as a natural process of coming together, we will not die in that sense. What we need now is a conceptual and aesthetic understanding of what is happening to us.

Of course when you say 'save the world' you mean avoid war, avoid famine, ok, ok. But the real point is understanding. And capitalism is impeaching our understanding. Because capitalism is suggesting some superstitions as natural, like growth, expansion, salary, competition. These are concepts. Words. Not natural things. We have to deconstruct the naturalization that capitalism has imposed on our life. And poetry is the preferred tool for doing that. Because poetry does not accept superstitions.

You know what superstition is? It is the super-position of a meaning. An *obliged* meaning imposed on the real life of the world. We want to have an autonomous life, but superstition obliges us otherwise. We have to disentangle the autonomous life of words. Poets can do that. This is their job. They have to understand it. Their job is not for a small minority of men of letters. No. It's a job that they have to do in the streets, among the children, the congregants of Greta Thunberg.

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